Introduction:

For millennia, philosophers, psychologists, and scientists have investigated mental illnesses in an effort to determine their root causes. Over the past few decades, new research has proven that numerous factors play a critical role in the manifestation of different disorders. A mental illness, defined by the National Library of Medicine, is "a syndrome characterized by a clinically significant disturbance in an individual's cognition, emotion regulation, or behavior that reflects a dysfunction in the psychological, biological, or developmental processes underlying mental functioning." [1] Additionally, physicality, as defined by Merriam-Webster Dictionary, means relating to the body of a person instead of the mind and having material existence.[2]

In order to address the ultimate level, it is imperative to understand which specific factor essentially paves the way for a mental illness to manifest. Though individual characteristics such as inheritable traits or gender may play a role in the ease of development, the foundation of the illness depends on its causation. Superficial research will suggest that all mental illnesses are physical, however, this essay will present evidence that clearly demonstrates that a multitude of social, cultural, and emotional factors undeniably cause many mental illnesses. These non-physical causes play a fundamental role in the development of mental illnesses such as eating disorders, anxiety, and depression.

The Social Contagion

Research shows a mental illness has the capacity to spread amongst human populations, similar to a contagious virus, thus, concretely illustrating the non-physical foundation of such a phenomenon. With complex social webs and endless forms of interaction, humans are deeply interconnected, causing traits and habits to spread throughout communities simply through behavior. The *Social Contagion Theory* demonstrates the unique ability of mental illnesses to spread like a contagious virus amongst human

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[1] American Psychiatric Association (2013). Diagnostic and statistical manual of mental disorders: DSM-5. Washington, DC: American Psychiatric Association.
[2] “Physical Definition & Meaning.” Merriam-Webster. Merriam-Webster. https://www.merriam-webster.com/dictionary/physical.

populations through behavioral traits. Psychology Today defines the theory as "the tendency for people to mimic the behavior of others who are either nearby or whom they have been exposed to."[3]

A landmark 2021 study in Denmark observing more than 250,000 employees over 12 years demonstrates this social characteristic.[4] The study determines that "when organizations hire employees from other organizations with a high prevalence of mental disorders, they "implant" depression, anxiety, and stress-related disorders into their workforces."[5] Numerous research studies find that aspects of one's emotional state (happiness, stress, anxiety, depression) spread similar to infectious diseases.[6] However, in contrast to contagious illnesses that spread through physical manners (sneezing, coughing, etc.), the "mode of transmission" for mental illnesses will be entirely psychological.[7] Therefore, because a mental illness such as depression can be spread throughout a population, it is evident that not all illnesses are ultimately physical.

Additionally, one such trigger for the social contagion is the chameleon effect, a psychological process where humans unknowingly pick up others' actions and mimic such behaviors.[8] A study conducted by the American Psychology Association uncovered that "participants unintentionally matched the behaviors of strangers with whom they worked on a task."[9] Thus, when a human exhibits physical mannerisms that cause mental illnesses such as depression or anxiety, humans unknowingly mimic such actions. Similarly, the Denmark study finds that the behavior of the "ill" coworker influenced others in the

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[3] "How Social Contagion Is Affecting US: Student Activities Blog: Liberty University." Student Activities, November 30, 2020.
[4]Ibid
[5] Ibid
[6] Eisenberg, Daniel, Ezra Golberstein, Janis L. Whitlock, and Marilyn F. Downs. "Social Contagion of Mental Health: Evidence from College Roommates." Health Economics 22, no. 8 (2012): 965–86. https://doi.org/10.1002/hec.2873.
[7] Kensbock, Julia M., Lars Alkærsig, and Carina Lomberg. "The Epidemic of Mental Disorders in Business—How Depression, Anxiety, and Stress Spread across Organizations through Employee Mobility*." *Administrative Science Quarterly* 67, no. 1 (2021): 1–48. https://doi.org/10.1177/00018392211014819.
[8] "Chameleon Effect: Why People Mimic Each Other." PsyBlog, August 21, 2021. https://www.spring.org.uk/2021/06/chameleon-effect.php.
[9] Chartrand, Tanya L., and John A. Bargh. "The Chameleon Effect: The Perception–Behavior Link and Social Interaction." Journal of Personality and Social Psychology 76, no. 6 (1999): 893–910. https://doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.76.6.893.

workplace, and they began to change their behaviors accordingly.[10] Specifically, the study claims coworkers unconsciously imitate "depressed, fearful, and stress-related emotions that [were] readily observed in facial expressions, movements, and postures" of others.[11] As a result, healthy individuals developed mental illnesses. Though genetics may make people more likely to develop mental illnesses, the manifestation of the illness relies on humans' environment and emotional behavior.

The Cultural Influence

Cultural pressures and societal norms make populations more susceptible to developing mental illnesses such as eating disorders and depression, a direct result of human influence, a non-physical factor. Classified by the National Alliance on Mental Illness, eating disorders are one of the most common mental illnesses affecting populations.[12] The two eating disorders (EDs) that will be discussed are anorexia nervosa (AN) and bulimia nervosa (BN) both of which detrimentally impact one's health.[13] Anorexia is characterized by an extreme fear of gaining weight, leading to over-dieting and a flawed perception of one's body.[14] While bulimia is a disorder characterized by overeating, i.e., binging, leading to purging excess calories in order to maintain body image.[15]

Various studies have found that the presence of unhealthy, unrealistic beauty norms have a direct correlation with the increase of eating disorders in young girls across the globe. Of the 70 million people living with eating disorders globally, 40% live in the United States.[16] Hence, when such a substantial number of individuals with EDs live in the United States, it is clear that it is not a question of genetics or

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[10] Kensbock, Julia M., Lars Alkærsig, and Carina Lomberg. “The Epidemic of Mental Disorders in Business—How Depression, Anxiety, and Stress Spread across Organizations through Employee Mobility*.” Administrative Science Quarterly 67, no. 1 (2021): 1–48. https://doi.org/10.1177/00018392211014819.
[11] Ibid
[12] “Eating Disorders.” NAMI. Accessed June 20, 2022. https://www.nami.org/About-Mental-Illness/Mental-Health-Conditions/Eating-Disorders.
[13] “Eating Disorders.” Mayo Clinic. Mayo Foundation for Medical Education and Research, February 22, 2018. https://www.mayoclinic.org/diseases-conditions/eating-disorders/symptoms-causes/syc-20353603.
[14] “Anorexia Nervosa.” Mayo Clinic. Mayo Foundation for Medical Education and Research, February 20, 2018. https://www.mayoclinic.org/diseases-conditions/anorexia-nervosa/symptoms-causes/syc-20353591.
[15] “Bulimia Nervosa.” Mayo Clinic. Mayo Foundation for Medical Education and Research, May 10, 2018. https://www.mayoclinic.org/diseases-conditions/bulimia/symptoms-causes/syc-20353615.
[16] “Statistics & Research on Eating Disorders.” National Eating Disorders Association, July 14, 2021. https://www.nationaleatingdisorders.org/statistics-research-eating-disorders.

"physical aspects" that are synonymous around the world, but factors specific to the culture of the United States. UPenn Professor McCarthy explains: "Specifically within Western society, women have a very finely tuned idea about what is an acceptable body, and rapidly internalize the current standard of female beauty."[17] This extreme internalization is referred to as the thin ideal: the western concept of an ideally slim or underweight female body. [18] The thin ideal has been proven to be an increasingly significant factor in the development of eating disorders by causing body dissatisfaction, negative moods, and low self-esteem.[19] Thus, if cultural and social factors ultimately trigger eating disorders, it is evident that the illness itself is not physical but merely a psychological response to extreme social pressure.

Moreover, recent research has found that no cases of bulimia have been detected in the absence of exposure to Western influences.[20] A study in Fiji that analyzed the effects of Western television on young girls demonstrated that Western ideology had not only shifted cultural views on body weight, but eating disorders that were once practically unheard of in Fiji substantially grew. [21] These expectations and pressures result in the psychological tendencies humans use to compare themselves to others. Humans are constantly viewing others, comparing themselves, and then changing to conform to society's "best."[22] At the most basic level, these expectations are merely emotional. Though the ideal body type of those suffering from eating disorders hope to one day "earn" may be a tangible goal, the reasoning behind achieving this goal is entirely psychological. Eating disorders stem from unhealthy minds, desperate for approval from others in order to conform to societal standards.

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[17] McCarthy, Mandy. “The Thin Ideal, Depression and Eating Disorders in Women.” Behavior Research and Therapy 28, no. 3 (1990): 205–14. https://doi.org/10.1016/0005-7967(90)90003-2.
[18] Swami, V. Cultural influences on body size ideals: Unpacking the impact of westernization and modernization. European Psychologist 20, 44-51 (2015)
[19] Hawkins, Nicole, P. Scott Richards, H. Mac Granley, and David M. Stein. “The Impact of Exposure to the Thin-Ideal Media Image on Women.” *Eating Disorders* 12, no. 1 (2004): 35–50. https://doi.org/10.1080/10640260490267751.
[20] Keel, P.K., & Klump, K.L. (2003). Are eating disorders culture bound syndromes? Implications for conceptualizing their etiology. Psychological Bulletin, 129, 747–769
[21] Becker, Anne E. “Television, Disordered Eating, and Young Women in Fiji: Negotiating Body Image and Identity during Rapid Social Change.” *Culture, Medicine and Psychiatry* 28, no. 4 (2004): 533–59. https://doi.org/10.1007/s11013-004-1067-5.
[22] Kong P, Harris LM. The sporting body: body image and eating disorder symptomatology among female athletes from leanness focused and non leanness focused sports. J Psychol. 2015;149:141–60.

Causation of eating disorders also commonly stems from peer pressure. A prominent aspect of ED behavior is found in large groups, specifically within college environments. For instance, among women living in sorority or dormitory housing, bulimia has often been observed in clusters, even to the extent of purging in groups."[23] Toxic eating habits not only cause the normalization of mental illnesses but also increase participation in ED behavior, consequently increasing the number of people with EDs. Though particular individuals may be more susceptible to succumbing than others, the ultimate factor of peer pressure is not physical. At the most basic level, peer pressure is human influence impacting decision-making. [24] A Cornell study on eating disorders "identified seven separate factors, of which the strongest (and in some cases the only factor significantly related to the outcome) was thin body preoccupation and social pressure."[25]

The Digital Age

Social media and online communication tools have also largely contributed to the pervasive spread of mental illness. Numerous studies have proven individuals continuously engaging in online media (chatrooms, social media, gaming) are much more likely to develop depression and anxiety. Specifically, a study that analyzed the effects of social media use on self-reported symptoms of depression and anxiety found, for the test group using media platforms, a 70% increase in depressive symptoms and a 42% increase in social anxiety symptoms.[26] According to Pew Research Center, "smartphone ownership has become a nearly ubiquitous element of teen life: 95% of teens now report they have a smartphone or

[23] Gordon, R. A. (1989). Bulimia: A sociocultural interpretation. In L. C. Whitaker & W. N. Davis (Eds.), The bulimic college student (pp.41–55). Binghamton, NY: Haworth Press
[24] "What Is Peer Pressure and Who Is at Risk?" Centerstone. Accessed June 22, 2022. https://centerstone.org/our-resources/health-wellness/what-is-peer-pressure-and-who-is-at-risk/.
[25] González, Beverly, Emilia Huerta-Sánchez, Angela Ortiz-Nieves, Terannie Vázquez-Alvarez, and Christopher Kribs-Zaleta. "Am I Too Fat? Bulimia as an Epidemic." *Journal of Mathematical Psychology* 47, no. 5-6 (2003): 515–26. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jmp.2003.08.002.
[26] Becker, Mark W., Reem Alzahabi, and Christopher J. Hopwood. "Media Multitasking Is Associated with Symptoms of Depression and Social Anxiety." Cyberpsychology, Behavior, and Social Networking 16, no. 2 (2013): 132–35. https://doi.org/10.1089/cyber.2012.0291.

access to one."[27] In fact, 45% of teens now say they are online on a near-constant basis.[28] Technology's impact on mental health is often underestimated, but strong correlations in data between an increase in internet usage and mental health conditions among youth prove high internet presence is a critical factor in the development of mental illnesses.[29]

Continuous internet-based interactions directly correlate with the increase in self-harm, self-poisoning, and hospital admittances due to mental health.[30] In the realm of technology, young people are constantly consuming harmful media content. When young people discuss and explicitly display occurrences of self-harm, a majority of the time, they are not met with conversations of recovery or positive affirmation.[31] Consequently, findings show this toxic online environment doesn't support those in need but perpetuates mental illness through the normalization of self-harm among youth.[32] Moreover, a study from Association for Psychological Science has connected usage for more than 2 hours on online networking sites with rates of suicide and depressive symptoms among young girls.[33] At the core, depression cases stemming from social media are simply emotional responses to toxic online environments.

Additionally, the human tendency to constantly compare oneself, especially on social media, can ultimately have extremely adverse effects on one's self-esteem, leading to the development of mental illnesses. Specifically, a 2014 study on Facebook uncovers the platform's impact on women's moods. The study split randomized participants into two groups: those viewing Facebook and those on an appearance-neutral control website. The research concluded that after spending just 10 minutes on their

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[27] Anderson, Monica, and Jingjing Jiang. “Teens, Social Media and Technology 2018.” Pew Research Center: Internet, Science & Tech. Pew Research Center, May 27, 2021.
[28] Ibid
[29] Abi-Jaoude, Elia, Karline Treurnicht Naylor, and Antonio Pignatiello. “Smartphones, Social Media Use and Youth Mental Health.” Canadian Medical Association Journal 192, no. 6 (2020). https://doi.org/10.1503/cmaj.190434.
[30] Ibid
[31] Lewis SP, Heath NL, Sornberger MJ, et al. Helpful or harmful? An examination of viewers’ responses to nonsuicidal self-injury videos on YouTube. J Adolesc Health 2012;51:380-5.
[32] Ibid
[33] Twenge JM, Joiner TE, Rogers ML, et al. Increases in depressive symptoms, suicide-related outcomes, and suicide rates among U.S. adolescents after 2010 and links to increased new media screen time. Clin Psychol Sci 2018;6:3–17. doi: 10.1177/2167702617723376.

Facebook account, participants reported a more negative mood than the control group.[34] Though the negative mood was an initial response to only 10 minutes of exposure, spending a near-constant amount of time on such platforms can ultimately lead to the development of mental illnesses such as depression. Furthermore, a study of 1,800 high school students in Taiwan found participants with an Internet addiction were closely associated with the incidence of self-harm/suicidal behavior in adolescents, both extreme symptoms of depression.[35]

Conclusion:

The evidence presented in this essay clearly demonstrates that non-physical attributes such as social contagions, toxic environments, and unhealthy media are potent influences that lead to the development of mental illnesses. In cases when the catalysts triggering the mental illness are not physical, the illness itself is an emotional response. Not only does this essay argue the paramount importance that one's environment plays in the development of mental illness, but also it opens the discussion on the prevention of such disorders. It is essential to understand the impact of external factors on one's life and decipher whether different stimuli play a positive or negative role in one's emotional state. In order to continuously support the 792 million living with mental illnesses globally, it is necessary to start at the source to uncover the actual triggers for mental illnesses.[36] Research from the Center of Social Psychiatry and Psychiatric Epidemiology demonstrates through numerous studies that depression and anxiety can be substantially reduced through preventive strategies.[37] Rather than placing emphasis on recovery approaches, mental illnesses can be dramatically reduced by establishing better prevention programs.

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[34] Abi-Jaoude, Elia, Karline Treurnicht Naylor, and Antonio Pignatiello. "Smartphones, Social Media Use and Youth Mental Health."

[35] Pan, Pei-Yin, and Chin-Bin Yeh. "Internet Addiction among Adolescents May Predict Self-Harm/Suicidal Behavior: A Prospective Study." The Journal of Pediatrics 197 (2018): 262–67. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jpeds.2018.01.046.

[36] Dattani, Saloni, Hannah Ritchie, and Max Roser. "Mental Health." Our World in Data, August 20, 2021. https://ourworldindata.org/mental-health.

[37] Mendelson, Tamar, and William W. Eaton. "Recent Advances in the Prevention of Mental Disorders." Social Psychiatry and Psychiatric Epidemiology 53, no. 4 (2018): 325–39. https://doi.org/10.1007/s00127-018-1501-6.

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